# Finding the Market: Identifying Viable Startup Clients for Research and Decision-Support Services

Portfolio project documentation. Exploratory market analysis of 26 startups across 5 countries, built with Excel, Power Query and Power BI.

## Project overview

This project asks where there is a real market for data, research, analytics and decision-support services among startups, what forms that need takes, and which types of startups are viable targets.

Rather than assuming what startups need, I built a dataset of 26 startups and coded what could be observed about each: country, sector, business model, funding stage, team size, funding evidence, internal research and analytics capability, estimated ability to pay and priority. I cleaned the data, analysed it against five business questions, and presented the results in a five-page Power BI dashboard.

**Headline result:** 25 of 26 startups showed a need, but only 15 (58%) were viable core targets once capability gaps and ability to pay were considered.

**Tools and skills:** Excel, Power Query (data cleaning and conditional columns), Power BI (dashboard design), DAX (measures and calculated columns), research design, data storytelling.

## Research purpose and business questions

**Purpose:** Where is there a real market for data, research, analytics and decision-support services among startups, what forms does that need take, and which types of startups should be considered viable targets or opportunities?

Five business questions guided the analysis:

1. In which sectors, countries and funding stages do startups show the strongest signs of need?
2. Where does a visible need coincide with the capacity to pay?
3. What forms does the need take, and does it differ by business model?

4. Do startups meet these needs in-house, through tools, or not at all, and where are the gaps?
5. What profile of startup combines need, ability to pay and low internal capability, and how large is that group?

## Methodology

**Sample.** 26 startups: Nigeria (11), United States (7), Kenya (5), United Kingdom (2) and India (1). They span AI, B2B SaaS, health tech, fintech and financial services, HR tech, logistics and retail. Business models are B2B (17), B2B2C (6), B2B + B2C (2) and B2B + B2G (1). Stages run from Pre-Seed to Series A.

**Data collection.** Each startup was coded from publicly available information. Need was coded as Yes or No for four need types: market research, customer research, business intelligence and decision support. Capability, ability to pay, priority tier and outsourcing potential were researcher-coded ratings.

**Cleaning.** Cleaning meant standardising categories that almost matched, splitting cells that held more than one response, trimming column headers, and removing a blank row that was inflating counts. The key discipline was asking whether each change made the data easier to analyse or quietly changed the story. Where I merged categories, I wrote the rule down.

**Derived fields.** Sector Group, Stage Group (combined stages mapped to the latest stage reached), Business Model Group, Team Size Group (1-10, 11-50, 51+), Capability Profile and Target Segment.

**Target Segment rules.** A startup is a **core target** if it shows all four needs, has low internal research capability, has Medium or High ability to pay, is Tier 1 priority and has high outsourcing potential. It is in the **wider market** if it meets the first three tests only. These thresholds are my judgement and are stated on the dashboard.

**Analysis and visualisation.** Descriptive analysis in Power BI: matrices, 100% stacked bars, profile charts, a funnel and a target list. I avoided over-slicing the sample, flagged small groups, and added sample sizes to chart titles.

# Findings

**1. Need is nearly universal, so it does not locate the market.** 25 of 26 startups showed all four need types. Only one showed none. Sector, country and stage charts of need mostly reflect where the sample sits, so they cannot show where need is higher.

**2. The differences are in capability.** 21 of 26 startups have low internal research capability, 4 moderate and 1 high. Analytics is better covered: 19 moderate, 5 high and 2 low. The gap is in research, not analytics. Pre-Seed and Seed startups are all low on research capability, and only Series A shows any strength. Eleven startups combine high data complexity with low research capability.

**3. Ability to pay is mostly modest.** 20 startups are rated Medium, 5 High and 1 Low. None of the five High payers has a low research gap. They are the five AI startups, all US-based and Series A, with disclosed funding of $24M to $255M. The startups with the biggest gaps have mid-range budgets.

**4. The viable group is large but narrower than need alone suggests.** The funnel runs 26 startups, 25 with need, 20 with low research capability and Medium or High ability to pay, and 15 once Tier 1 priority and high outsourcing potential are applied. That gives 15 core targets (58%) and 20 in the core plus wider market (77%).

**5. Profile of the core targets.** 14 of the 15 are Pre-Seed or Seed, 9 are B2B, 4 are B2B2C and 2 are B2B + B2C, and 10 have teams of 11 to 50 people. Ten are Nigerian health and fintech startups. The other five are B2B SaaS startups in the UK (2), US (2) and India (1), with disclosed funding of $1.2M to $5M.

**6. Business model.** B2B is the largest segment, but B2B2C startups converted to core targets at a higher rate (4 of 6, against 9 of 17). No pure B2C startups were sampled, so that segment is untested.

# Recommendations

1. **Lead with research and decision support.** The widest gap is in research, so market research, customer research and decision support should come first. Keep analytics and reporting as secondary offers, since most startups already cover them partly in-house.
2. **Primary target:** early-stage (Pre-Seed and Seed) B2B startups with 11 to 50 people, especially Nigerian health and fintech companies. Price and scope services for early-stage budgets, for example project-based research and light-touch decision support rather than large retainers.

3. **Secondary target:** Seed-stage B2B SaaS startups in the UK, US and India. They show the clearest ability to pay among the startups with a gap.
4. **Treat B2B2C and hybrid models as a strong next segment.** They show a research gap as wide as B2B's. Use different approaches for different segments, because stage and market change what buyers will pay.
5. **Deprioritise well-resourced Series A startups.** The AI startups can pay but have less need for outside research.
6. **Validate before scaling.** Test the primary segment through short interviews or a survey on budget and current research practice.

## Limitations

- **Small, non-random sample.** 26 startups, mostly Nigerian, so results are indicative and cannot be generalised to startups overall.
- **Researcher-coded ratings.** Capability, ability to pay, priority and outsourcing potential are my judgements from public information, not verified internally.
- **Thin funding evidence.** Funding is disclosed for only 6 of the 15 core targets, so ability to pay for the Nigerian group is largely estimated.
- **Need does not discriminate.** Because 25 of 26 startups show all four needs, need type cannot be used to rank services. The case for research rests on the capability gap.
- **Threshold sensitivity.** The core target group depends on the rules I chose. Different thresholds would change its size.
- **No data on tool use.** The dataset has no field for whether startups use software in place of people, so the "through tools" part of the capability question is unanswered.
- **Small subgroups.** Several business model, stage and country groups have only one to five startups.
- **No pure B2C startups,** so conclusions about B2C are untested.

## Next steps

Broaden the sample beyond Nigeria and Kenya, add pure B2C startups, add a tools-usage field, code the strength of evidence per startup, and test the primary segment through direct conversations.